

Dell to make cell?

The long rumoured phone called Mini 3, based on the Android OS will probably come out at the end of the year

Zii to get 3G

If rumours are to be believed then Creative's Zii Egg will get a 3G chip soon and transform into a smartphone running on Android

platform. The move puts Twitter in the hands of millions of potential customers. All customers have to do, is text the short-code START to 53000. "There are over one billion people with internet access on the planet, but there are more than four billion people with mobile phones, and Twitter can work on all of them because even the simplest of these devices feature SMS," says Twitter Co-Founder Biz Stone on the official Twitter blog. The deal will remain exclusive for a month, after which operators other than Airtel can offer the same services to their subscribers.

Tata DoCoMo on the other hand was dabbling in Momics – comics on mobile. It was planning to bring Manga – Japanese comics which have their own peculiar style – via a downloadable application called 'Comix On The Go' to Indian consumers. Meanwhile Airtel has announced a comic portal on their deck that will provide 300 Indian and International comics. The comics are being offered through a partnership with ROK comics. The site (wap.rokcomics.com) can be accessed by anyone but data charges will apply. We noticed a few interesting Indian titles such as Shivaji, Birbal the witty, and Rani of Jhansi, while international titles include BC and Hagar. If comics are not properly ported to the mobile format, they tend to get a little fuzzy. The text becomes especially unreadable on the small screen.

Who wins? You!

Mobile entertainment consumers as well as content providers are going dizzy with the possibilities that 3G is likely to provide in this space. Once the spectrum auctioning niggles are ironed out, it will really mark the next stage of entertainment evolution. Faster data speeds equals richer content, including multiplayer gaming. "So for instance players can be located as far apart as Mumbai and Delhi, and play something like cricket or tennis in real time. You can bowl from one place and take a shot from another. We're doing some R&D in this

CULTURE OF CONNECTIVITY

Earlier mobile internet enthusiasts would download widgets or applications for accessing specific services online. So you would have an application for Gmail, an application for Yahoo!, Wikipedia, and so on. The trouble with going this way was that you constantly needed to switch between applications to use the services. We now have browsers (both native as well as third party) that give you a full internet experience so people are moving away from using widgets and dedicated apps to using browsers just like from their PCs. Most people prefer a third-party browser such as Opera Mini or SkyFire.

area as well. We see gaming take off in a big way," says Rajiv of Mobile2Win.

Samir Bangra, COO of Indiagames.com, however has a slightly different view on the



Rajiv Hiranandani
Co-founder of Mobile2Win

"Players located as far apart as Mumbai and Delhi can play active games in real time when 3G gets rolled out in a big way"



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whole 3G roll out. According to him, "As a mobile entertainment company, we're of course very excited, still, there's what we call a ripple effect of the 3G roll out, that has to be dealt with. This essentially is solving the problem of spectrum availability of the operators. Networks are so badly choked, that operators are not able to divert any of their bandwidth for data. While charges for data services will be taken by operators, networks may not support them." Bangra

expects at least 20 per cent of the market to switch to 3G plans mostly from the category A circles and not the tier II and II towns. For these adopters Indiagames has some interesting plans. "We'll take them to a far superior gaming experience than they're experiencing today. From 300 kb we'll go up to 2 meg. A Bruce Lee game we're working on right now for the iPhone is likely to be a 90

These displays almost all web pages exactly as they would be rendered on a desktop PC only scaled down for a smaller screen. Another similar browser is TeaShark or the newly released Bolt browser from Bitstream. With this new wave of always on connectivity, people with unlimited advanced GPRS plans a.k.a mobile internet enthusiasts will also go to random web sites like icanhascheezburger.com, failblog.org or the Photoshop disaster blog, and basically find various means to stay entertained. This includes getting on to you tube and watching loads of streaming video

MB game. This will be released on several platforms as well. These games of the 3G era will be far richer in graphic quality, sound and gameplay." We were very curious about the multiplayer capabilities that can be achieved through 3G. "This is a question that is on everyone's mind right now, and I hate to be a wet blanket, but we'll still be stuck with turn-based gameplay. Pingpong, tennis, cricket can be conceived, but not shooting or racing where the lag might render it unplayable. Realtime is too much to ask of a network, even 3G," he added.

According to Simone, 3G will give an immense boost to music content too. "Music content which includes CRBT, ringtones, full song and music on demand (combined) is the largest premium content market in India and as per our estimate it is expected to grow at the rate of 50 per cent for the next 3 to 4 years. Next, with the introduction of 3G this will increase only further", he explains.

If we had to play soothsayer, we'd guess that mobile TV will come up in a big way thanks to the huge data pipeline 3G promises. We'll see loads of special made-for-mobile episodes that will be 3 to 5 minutes long, created specially for mobile delivery. Quickly following mobile TV, advertisers will figure out how to adapt to the small screen format, because people will increasingly spend a lot more time on their handsets. We will shoot rich content, in higher resolutions, and be busy posting it all on the social networking site of our choice. Honestly, we've ceased to think "if" and are now only wondering "when?". Keep your fingers crossed, because all this could become commonplace in just a couple of years. 

